

Acer PD-726W

The Black Knight

Perhaps the best looking of the test candidates, Acer's large PD-726W comes in an attractive yet sober black-silver colour tone. The build quality is laudable.

One sore point—the remote will not interface with the projector if you are seated directly behind the unit. To use the remote from behind the projector you'll need to elevate the remote or come to either side (left or right) or in front of the projector. The second gripe is with the remote buttons—they are too hard; a complete lack of tactility.

The minimum throw distance of 2.85 metres is on the high side, not suitable for confined spaces.

The PD-726W offers connectivity galore with Component, S-Video, RCA, D-Sub, DVI, and even HDMI. Network connectivity is via RJ45 and Wi-Fi. Interfacing with the device is possible through RS-232 and USB (both USB A and B type connects are provided in the package).

The menu interface is good, and the PD-726W has a lot of extra networking options. It allows specifying an IP address to which a message can be automatically sent if anything goes wrong.

The PD726W was the brightest amongst all our tests subjects, while not suffering contrast deficiencies (2500:1).

During calibration the 256-shade intensity screen gave excellent results—there were no transitions visible from changes of intensity of a particular colour. The PD-726W renders reds the best from the lot that came for testing. It performed well in the presentation tests and should make a very capable boardroom partner. However, we didn't like the rendition in photographs: our test photos were missing some of

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the finer details. Our business readers will be happy to note that text reproduction is sharp.

Halos that appeared around extremely light colours would disappear by tuning brightness and contrast settings, but we do not adjust anything once we finish calibrating, so the PD-726W lost out here.

The PD726W makes for a great movie projector with sharp image rendition and great contrast. Throw a couple of games at it and it'll shine even more. *F.E.A.R.* looked virtually as crisp as it looks on a desktop monitor!

With some sterling scores across the board, our Best Buy Gold Award is Acer's, as their PD-726W smokes out the other contenders, though there were some close scores. It's suitable for most users, and will handle business and multimedia applications equally well. Although its heavy with corporate features, the inclusion of hardcore multimedia features such as HDMI makes Acer's PD-726W top dog in the entertainment sphere as well.

Epson EMP-1715

Feature-rich, fancy-free!

Epson's EMP-1715 was the definitive plain-jane in our test labs. Grey and beige don't do much for style, while the boxy contours stick to the stereotype. That's not to say the EMP-1715 is any less a projector.

It's built well; the only problem with the structural design as far as we could tell was the air inlet, which is placed at the bottom. This would surely restrict or inhibit air flow, especially when the projector isn't elevated. We'd have preferred the air intake on one of the sides to remedy this. The EMP1715 did get rather hot during our tests. All projectors heat up; this one seemed a few degrees higher than the others.

Epson focuses on the business segment with the EMP-1715, and this is apparent with the limited video connectivity—D-Sub, S-Video, and RCA. The common RS-232 interface is also absent; thankfully, USB connects (A and B types) are provided.

Wi-Fi makes an appearance on the EMP-1715. The options are

very good; once again, diagnostics and IP messaging (in case of problems) is possible. RJ45 connectivity is absent, though.

The EMP-1715 has a reasonably long throw. Epson claims a maximum throw distance of 12.1 metres. This makes it more suitable for larger conference rooms. It can also be used in tighter spaces, with a minimum throw distance of 1.2 meters.

The DisplayMate Suite performed reasonably well on the EMP-1715, except for the colour tests. We had problems with streaky blacks in the black-level shift test. The EMP-1715 also has problems with rendering colour transitions. For example, when moving from lighter to darker shades of red, the gradations were clearly noticeable instead of the smooth transition one expects.

When it came to our PowerPoint slide tests, text wasn't as clear as we'd have wanted it—there was noticeable blurring



around the edges. Although the text and graphs were indeed clearly legible, we expected much more. Photograph quality was all right, though detail in darker colours was lost, which smacks of an inadequate contrast ratio.

Movie-watching was fun on the EMP-1715—good colour rendition, and none of the blurriness or tearing (a display anomaly) that usually happens in fast action movies. However, it wasn't near the NEC NP40 and the Acer PD-726W as sheer picture quality and clarity go.

Gaming isn't much fun on this projector. The lack of contrast and detail is immediately noticeable, and this is a problem for the latest crop of games.

Epson's EMP-1715 is a business oriented projector. It's not much in the way of a home entertainment device. Unfortunately, it has a few quirks with performance in its own area—the business tests.

At Rs 1,54,000, the EMP-1715 commands too hefty a price tag for the performance it places at your disposal. It's a feature-rich projector that fails to project itself past that significant "must-buy" line.